liberal attitude toward Pakistani debt rescheduling, and stated that Pakistan would get military equipment that the US had sanctioned earlier.[155]

This reluctance to push Yahya toward compromise continued after the White House had established direct channels to China. Nixon and Kissinger were grateful for Yahya's role in establishing the channel. They were also concerned that US pressure on Pakistan "might be misunderstood in Peking" and seen as a joint Soviet-American action. Thus, in subsequent meetings with the Chinese leadership, Kissinger would repeatedly state American support for Pakistan.[156]

Could Sino-US rapprochement have survived increased American pressure on Pakistan? China had its own motivations for the rapprochement. Furthermore, its support to Islamabad had not gone beyond some military supplies and rhetorical and political backing.[157] As early as March, a US interagency group had assessed that Chinese military intervention to aid Pakistan was highly unlikely since Beijing would consider it "high risk, low benefit."[158] At a meeting in July, Zhou had told Kissinger that "if India commits aggression, we will support Pakistan," but he left the nature of that assistance ambiguous.[159] Defending his perspective, the national security adviser later noted that his belief that China was more seriously committed to Pakistan was based on his interpretation of Zhou's statement that "China would not be indifferent if India attacked Pakistan."[160] With this assumption, Nixon and Kissinger believed that China would see a "victory of India over Pakistan" as "the same as a victory of the Soviet Union over China."[161]

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India, on its part, sought assurances from the superpowers to ensure that it would be prepared if China went beyond supporting Pakistan diplomatically. In early June, on a trip to Moscow, Swaran Singh told Andrei Gromyko that China's potential role was a crucial issue for India, especially given Zhou's "strong and belligerent statements" in support of Pakistan. He said there was a "good deal of circumstantial evidence which indicates a positive collusion between China and Pakistan." Singh suggested that China's opposition to India stemmed mainly from India's close relationship with the Soviet Union. He noted, "A situation may arise, which may demand the entry of the Soviet Union … to encounter the